

and UNICEF in 2020. If India's flagship routine immunisation programme, Mission Indradhanush, was dealt a massive blow, the direct impact on adolescent and adult vaccination uptake was obvious. "If one looks at the type of vaccines that have de-grown significantly, a majority of them fall in the adult vaccines category," says Sheetal Sapale, President-Marketing, AWACS, adding that Covid-19 may be a possible reason for the dip in adult inoculations. As for the fall in children's vaccinations, she says it could be because many couples postponed having children during the pandemic (most such vaccines are given within the first year of birth).

THE PANDEMIC has made individuals, including adolescents, aware of the importance of a jab. With an uptick in the number of adolescents receiving Covid-19 shots, the central government is planning to review its life-course vaccination schedules, say sources in the health ministry. "Covid-19 vaccination uptake in adolescents proves that a mass vaccination programme can be successful for all age groups in India. We have been pushing for an adolescent immunisation programme and consulting with the states," says Dr N.K. Arora, Chair, National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation (NTAGI), which is under the health ministry.

72 | The government, meanwhile, has approved four Covid-19 vaccines for adolescents: Bharat Biotech's Covaxin for 15 years and above; Zydus Cadila's ZyCov-D for 12 years and above; Biological E.'s Corbevax (12-18 years); and Novavax's protein-based Covid-19 vaccine, which Serum Institute of India (SII) will market as Covovax (for 12-17 years age group).

This has given a fillip to pharma companies that are looking to invest in the space. For SII, which makes Covishield for adults, Covovax is the missing piece of its Covid-19 vaccine puzzle: Covishield isn't approved for use in adolescents,

though it makes up the bulk of jabs given in India. "Now, SII can target adolescents through Covovax," says Prashant Khadayat, Pharma Analyst at GlobalData, a data and analytics firm. Covaxin leads the 15-18 years segment, while Corbevax dominates the 12-14-year segment. "Vaccination among adolescents should grow after the Covid-19 experience. HPV (human papilloma virus) can prevent cervical cancer; other vaccines can prevent... other deadly diseases," says SII CEO Adar Poonawalla. Besides SII, other Covid-19 vaccine manufacturers like Bharat Biotech are also looking at the adolescent segment.

Pfizer, one of the market leaders in pneumococcal vaccines, says it has consistently tried to raise awareness of pneumococcal disease and the need to prevent it since childhood. "The pandemic has transformed the way healthcare information is sought and consumed, with digital platforms playing a critical role in this process," says S. Sridhar, MD, Pfizer Limited. Agrees Dr Parag Sheth, Regional Medical Director, Abbott India, who adds that bridging knowledge gaps about vaccination options is crucial to scaling up immunisation.

BUT WHAT is the need for mass vaccination programmes for adolescents? The WHO's Scientific Advisory Group of Experts to the Global Programme for Vaccines and Immunization has indicated the need to expand immunisation beyond infancy. Community health experts say that vaccines help in protecting the community by curtailing the spread of infectious diseases along with protecting the vaccinated individual from developing a potentially serious disease.

According to the health ministry, there is a sizeable disease burden due to VPDs in adolescents and adults, which is responsible for large economic losses directly and indirectly. A study published in the journal *Indian Pediatrics (IP)*, the official publication of the Indian Academy of Pediatrics (IAP), says adolescent immunisation is one of the most vital yet neglected fields in India. There is no adolescent-specific schedule in the government's UIP. Though a separate adolescent immunisa-

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